

Some Voters Ask AI Chatbots About Their Ballots

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Voting in the 2026 **midterm elections** has started in the United States. Some voters are trying something new. They ask AI **chatbots** to help them learn about the **candidates**, NPR reports.

Adam Johnson, 40, lives in Morgantown, West Virginia. One September evening, he spent hours going over his **ballot** with ChatGPT. He asked it to compare **candidates** based on what he cares about. He said the **chatbot** is "kind of a people pleaser."

Other voters use **chatbots** to learn about small local races and to check claims they see online. Lisa Veldran of Wisconsin used a **chatbot** called Gemini to compare two **candidates** for **governor**. In Pennsylvania, Lakshmi Iyer used a **chatbot** called Claude to build a website that helps voters.

Experts say to be careful. Rafael Batista of Johns Hopkins University said **chatbots** may push people toward what they already believe. **Chatbots** can also give wrong or made-up answers.

Word Treasure

ballot -- The list of choices a voter marks when voting.

candidate -- A person who wants to be elected to a job.

chatbot -- A computer program you can type questions to and get answers from.

midterm elections -- U.S. elections held in the middle of a president's four-year term.

governor -- The leader of a U.S. state.

Break it down

Voters try a new way to get ready for the election
Adam Johnson uses ChatGPT for his ballot
Other voters use chatbots in different ways
Experts say to be careful

Why it matters

More people are using AI to learn about elections, so it helps to know how these tools work and why their answers should be checked.

Test what you remember

1. What are some voters asking AI chatbots to help with?

- ☐ (A) Cooking dinner
- ☐ (B) Picking a new pet
- ☐ (C) Learning about the candidates on their ballots
- ☐ (D) Fixing their cars

2. Which chatbot did Adam Johnson use?

- ☐ (A) Claude
- ☐ (B) ChatGPT
- ☐ (C) None at all
- ☐ (D) Gemini

3. Where does Adam Johnson live?

- ☐ (A) Paris, France
- ☐ (B) Nashville, Tennessee
- ☐ (C) Morgantown, West Virginia
- ☐ (D) Madison, Wisconsin

4. How did Johnson describe the chatbot?

- ☐ (A) Always perfectly fair
- ☐ (B) Very rude
- ☐ (C) Too slow to use
- ☐ (D) "Kind of a people pleaser"

5. What did Lakshmi Iyer build with a chatbot?

- ☐ (A) A website that helps voters
- ☐ (B) A robot
- ☐ (C) A video game
- ☐ (D) A new school

6. What is one problem experts warn about?

- ☐ (A) Chatbots cannot read
- ☐ (B) Chatbots can give wrong or made-up answers
- ☐ (C) Chatbots cost a million dollars
- ☐ (D) Chatbots only work at night

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: C 4: D 5: A 6: B

Questions to think about

- 1. Voters who use chatbots: Say chatbots help them research candidates and local races.**
- 2. Expert Rafael Batista: Warns chatbots may push people toward what they already believe.**

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):